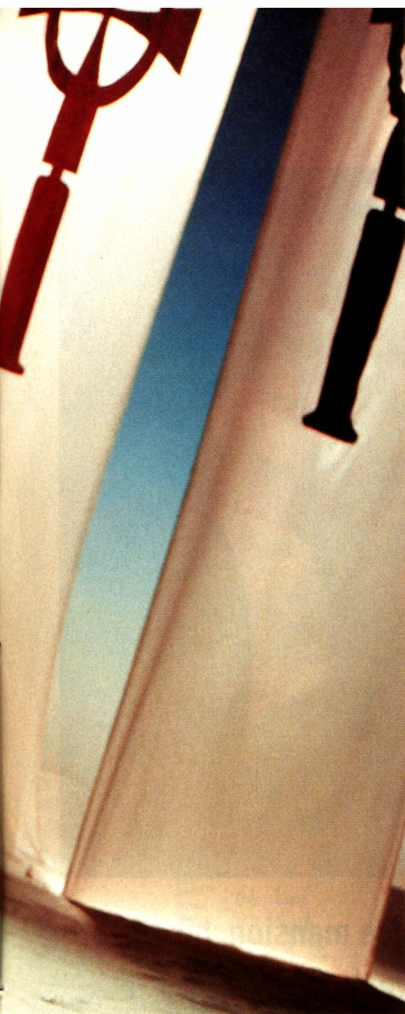




with the smarts in *Kya Aap Paanchvi Pass Se Tez Hain?* to the item boy in the sparkly holster of *Krazzy 4* to the 12th man who is bigger than the Team XI—no matter who is playing, he is always the centre of attention. In the cult of Shah Rukh Khan, there is room for just one icon. “No

one can get tired of me,” he says with his typical understatement. Brand builder Anirban Das Blah, from a tribe Shah Rukh considers superfluous, puts it in corporate terms: “He is simply the biggest marketing phenomenon in the Indian entertainment industry as he straddles every area of it.” Does this straddling arise from a deep-seated insecurity or enormous self-belief? Even Shah Rukh’s often charming glibness would not have an answer.

He also scores over his contemporaries in his diaspora appeal. Of the top five Hindi box office grossers in the US, four are his films, garnering a collective revenue of \$12.7 million (Rs 51

Rs **150** cr
net box office revenue
of his 2007 releases
Chak De! India and
Om Shanti Om

crore). Last year, he made newspaper headlines in Germany by just showing up at the Berlin Film Festival, while in Paris’s Montmartre this week, he says—and “I don’t like to boast”—even his family was taken aback by the 1,000 people who had gathered there, a few even carrying the “Korbo, Lorbo, Jeetbo” banner.

But more than the 50 films in his oeuvre, his *videsi* appeal, and his eclectic interests (which range from reading Ayn Rand to watching Manchester United games), there is perhaps one element where he triumphs over others. He is a great storyteller, the old fashioned village square kind who gathers the no-good fellows around him for a bit of a yarn. Sometimes the Khan *ki kahani* is about himself, part of the great folklore of struggle surrounding him—the middle-class Delhi boy who loses his parents young, comes alone to the big city of Mumbai, says to the sea he will own it one day, does so, his success

perience with the Rs 15-crore *Paheli* showed, not even his generous backing as a producer can prevent a turkey.

In terms of his movie career, he is working less than the slog-master Akshay Kumar, whose four films in 2007 grossed Rs 350 crore, while in the endorsement stakes, the super exclusive Aamir Khan charges more per brand (Rs 8-10 crore, which has gone up to Rs 12 crore for his new endorsement, Samsung). Where Shah Rukh scores is in his ability to reinvent himself across different arenas, from the inspirational sports leader of *Chak De! India* to the man with the six pack abs in *Om Shanti Om*, from the teacher

